

Session 16: Oracles Against the Nations

Key Takeaways

- Israel is ethnically related to many of these surrounding nations. Their hostility pits brother against brother, reflecting the Cain and Abel story.
- The oracles are designed in two cycles of seven, connecting to Genesis 1 and 7 and the themes of de-creation and re-creation.
- Ezekiel portrays the king of Tyre as a cherub cast down from a place of honor in Eden, linking rebellious human kingdoms with the influence of rebellious spiritual beings.

Ezekiel 25-32: Oracles Against the Seven Nations Around Israel

This collection of oracles interrupts the prediction of a refugee coming from Jerusalem ([Ezek. 24:25-27](#)) and his arrival to announce the city's downfall ([Ezek. 33:21-23](#)). However, these oracles all date to precisely the time period between the death of Ezekiel's wife ([Ezek. 24:1](#), Jan. 588 B.C.E.) and the coming of the refugee three years later ([Ezek. 33:21](#), Jan. 585 B.C.E.). Moreover, this collection of materials shows all the signs of an intentional and elegant literary ordering. The 18 oracles are organized in a unique symmetry by a pattern of sevens and an even distribution of word amounts. There are oracles against seven nations, the final two (Tyre and Sidon together, then Egypt) receiving seven oracles each.

Located precisely in the middle of this material in terms of word count (nations 1-6 have 97 verses dedicated to them; nation 7 has 97 verses as well), we find a short oracle ([Ezek. 28:25-26](#)) directed not toward the nations, but rather toward Israel and its status among the nations after they are judged.

The center oracle of 28:25-26 has been deliberately placed as the fulcrum of this material, making it clear that Ezekiel's oracles against the nations are not primarily an expression of tribal hatred, but rather part of Ezekiel's rhetorical goal to pave a way for the oracles of hope that lie ahead in chapters 34-48. If Yahweh is against these nations around Israel, then by implication he is still for his covenant people. However, the Israel he is "for" is the purged and refined Israel that has come through the searing judgment of chapters 12-24.

Number of nations	1	2	3	4	5	6						7										
Nations	Ammon	Moab	Edom	Philistia	Tyre + Sidon							Israel Restored	Egypt									
Number of oracles	1	1	1	1	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	28:25-26	1	2	3	4	5	6	7			
Chapters	25	25	25	25	26	27						28		29	30		31	32				
Number of Verses			97 verses							97 verses												

Ezekiel 25-32 Design. Block, Daniel (1998). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans.

Key Themes in the Oracles Against the Nations

Yahweh's Providence Over Human Affairs

Yahweh is at work in the affairs and events of nations that do not involve Israel (Babylon, Tyre, and Egypt, see [Ezek. 29:17-20](#)). Yahweh oversees the affairs of nations to move forward his particular redemptive plan in and through Israel (Babylon becomes Yahweh's unwitting tool, see [Ezek. 21:23-29](#)).

Yahweh Holds All Nations Accountable to Basic Standards of Justice

Ezekiel's accusations are against the same behaviors for which he accuses Israel: violence, idolatry, and self-exaltation.

Yahweh's Ultimate Goal Is To Make Himself Known to the Nations

The phrase, "they/you will know that I am Yahweh" occurs with greatest density in this section of the book (23x in these seven chapters), and is parallel to Israel's coming to "know Yahweh" through judgment and restoration.

This theme is the only hint in Ezekiel of some redemptive future for the nations; Yahweh's greatest concern is for his own reputation and status among the nations ([Ezek. 36:18-21](#)).

"We are dealing not merely with prophecies that were some kind of comfort to Israel in their loss and disorientation, but with actions of God on the stage of human history that were intended to be revelatory. People would see and know something about the living God through all that is spoken of here. The purpose of these oracles was not to fan Israelite nationalism, but to envisage the next stage of God's long-term mission of being universally known among the nations of the world."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit](#). IVP Academic. 233.

Oracles Against Israel's Immediate Neighbors

Ezekiel 25 is a rapid succession of oracles against the nations surrounding Israel, going clockwise from the north: Ammon (25:1-7), Moab (25:8-11), Edom (25:12-14), and Philistia (25:15-17).

Three of these nations had kinship ties to Israel (Ammon and Moab being connected to Abraham through Lot, see [Gen. 19:30-38](#); Edom connected to Esau, see [Gen. 36](#)). All three had a history of conflict and uneasy alliance with Israel. However, in the time of Ezekiel, all four had banded together in rebellion against Babylon (see [Jer. 27](#)). When Babylon chose to sack Jerusalem as an example to others ([Ezek. 21:21-29](#) depicts Nebuchadnezzar's "coin-toss" about which capital city to destroy), all the "allies" turned on Jerusalem in mockery (Moab, Ammon, Philistia) or outright betrayal and violence (Edom, see [Obad. 1:14](#)).

These oracles, which have parallels in Jeremiah (Ammon, [Jer. 49:1-6](#); Moab, [Jer. 48:1-47](#); Edom, [Jer. 49:7-22](#); and Philistia, [Jer. 47:1-7](#)), emphasize that nations in such close proximity to the knowledge of Yahweh will face his justice for their betrayal and evil.

Seven Oracles Against Tyre and Sidon

Each oracle begins with the same exact expression: "thus says Lord Yahweh" ([Ezek. 26:1, 7, 15; 27:1; 28:1; 28:11; 28:20](#)).

Tyre was the trading and maritime capital of the Phoenicians and was a long-time trading partner with Israel on good terms ([1 Kgs. 5](#)). The city was a high-walled castle on a large island just off the coast of modern Lebanon, and its harbor boasted the largest fleet of trading ships in the ancient world. They traded as far as Spain, Britain, and Greece, and so Tyre was known as a center of opulent wealth. These oracles focus on the treachery of Tyre against Israel in the Babylonian period, as well as its heavy economic dominance and the social corruption that resulted.

#1 Tyre's Agenda for Jerusalem ([Ezek. 26:1-6](#))

Tyre sees Jerusalem's downfall as a chance for economic gain ([Ezek. 26:1-6](#)).

#2 Yahweh Brings Babylon Against Tyre ([Ezek. 26:7-14](#))

[Ezekiel 26:7-14](#): See the follow up to this prediction of the Babylonian siege on Tyre in [Ezekiel 29:17-21](#). The siege lasted 13 years and exhausted both parties until Babylon gave up.

#3 Tyre's Downfall Among the Nations ([Ezek. 26:15-21](#))

Tyre will become a byword among the princes of the coast ([Ezek. 26:15-21](#)).

#4 Funeral Lament for the Shipwreck of Tyre ([Ezek. 27:1-36](#))

In an elaborate metaphorical poem, Ezekiel depicts Tyre as a high-end trading ship (27:4-11) loaded with exotic goods from its distant trading allies. 27:12-25 lists Tyre's trading partners and their characteristic wares.

Ezekiel's knowledge of international trade is remarkable and builds up a portrait of wealth leading to arrogance and hubris.

In 27:26-27, the ship is rowed out to sea only to be swamped by a gigantic storm (driven by an "east wind," same as Exod. 14:21!). The ship sinks offshore in view of an international crowd of spectators and mourners (27:28-32) who begin to sing a lament on its behalf (27:33-36).

This chapter (Ezek. 27:1-36) was a major resource for John the visionary's description of the wealth and corruption of Babylon/Rome in Revelation 18. The connection seems to have been triggered by Ezekiel's connection of great wealth leading to the grandiose divine self-exaltation of Tyre's leaders (Ezek. 28:1-2, 6-9) in a way similar to Isaiah's depiction of Babylon (Isa. 47:7-11).

#5 The Fall of Tyre's Arrogant Leader (Ezek. 28:1-10)

In 28:1-10, Ezekiel's focus turns from the nation to its king (Ethbaal III, named after Jezebel's father with whom Ahab made an alliance 200 years earlier, 1 Kgs. 16:31).

He depicts the mindset of the king as deluded with dreams of divine status (28:1-2). While Egyptian kings commonly thought of themselves as divine, this was not a claim made by any known Canaanite leaders. Likely Ezekiel interprets the arrogant behavior of the king as a claim to act in the place of God, driven by his economic influence and dominance (28:3-5).

¹ And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying,

² "Son of a human,

say to the chief of Tyre,

'Thus says Lord Yahweh:

Because **your heart was raised high**,

and you said,

"I am El,

I sit in the seat of Elohim,

in **the heart** of the seas."

But **you are a human and not El**,

and **you have made your heart like the heart of Elohim**.

³ Look, are you more **wise** than Daniel?

Is there no hidden thing that overwhelms you?

⁴ By your **wisdom** and understanding you have made wealth for yourself,

and you have made gold and silver for your treasures,

⁵ By your great **wisdom**, with your trade you have increased your wealth,

and **your heart is raised high** because of your wealth.

⁶ Therefore, thus says Lord Yahweh:

Because **you have set your heart like the heart of Elohim**,

⁷ for that reason I am about to bring upon you violent foreign nations,

and they will unsheathe their swords against the beauty of your wisdom,

and they will defile your radiance.

⁸ They will make you go down to the pit,
and you will die the death of the slain,
in the heart of the seas.

⁹ Will you really say

“**I am an Elohim**”

before your those who execute you?

So **you are a human and not El**,

in the hand of those who slay you.

¹⁰ You will die the death of the uncircumcised at the hand of foreigners,
for I have spoken.

Utterance of Lord Yahweh.'

Ezekiel 28:1-10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

#6 An Edenic Analogy for Tyre's Fallen Leader (Ezek. 28:11-19)

In 28:11-19, the metaphors of the king's divine claim (28:1-2) are developed into a full-blown metaphorical vision (typical of Ezekiel) using Israelite (and perhaps other Mesopotamian) traditions of the primeval origins of humanity.

There are two alternate versions of this oracle preserved in the textual witnesses, each asserting different things about the king, both related to the main themes of the Eden narrative in Genesis 2-3.

Ezekiel 28:12-19 in the Hebrew Text Underneath the Septuagint

Differences are marked with italics, and additions are bracketed in bold.

Ezekiel 28:12-19 Instructor's Translation

And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying:

¹² Son of a human,

take up a funeral song about the king of Tyre,

and you shall say to him,

'Thus says Lord Yahweh,

You were a proportioned seal,

and complete in beauty.

¹³ You were in Eden, the garden of *Elohim*,

every precious stone was your covering,

ruby, topaz, and emerald,

turquoise, sapphire, and jasper

carnelian, agate, and amethyst

[chrysolite, beryl, and onyx]

and settings and your mountings

were a work of gold

in the day you were created.

¹⁴ *With the cherub I set you;*
you were in the holy mountain of *Elohim*,
in the midst of the stones of fire.

¹⁵ You were blameless in your ways
from the day you were created,
until iniquity was found in you.

¹⁶ Due to the abundance of your trade,
your midst was filled with violence
and you sinned,
so I defiled you from the mountain of *Elohim*,
and *the cherub banished you*
from the midst of the fiery stones.

¹⁷ Your heart was raised high due to your beauty,
you corrupted your wisdom with your radiance,
[because of your many sins]
I cast you down to the ground,
I give you over to kings, to look upon you.

¹⁸ Because of your great iniquities
in the wickedness of your trade,
you defiled your sanctuaries,
so I bring out fire from your midst,
it consumes you
and I will set you in the dust of the land,
in the eyes of all who see you.

¹⁹ All who know you among the peoples,
they will be appalled at you,
you will be an object of horror
and you will be no more.

Ezekiel 28:12-19 in the Masoretic Text

Differences are marked with italics, and additions are bracketed in bold.

Ezekiel 28:12-19 Instructor's Translation

And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying:

¹² Son of a human,
take up a funeral song about the king of Tyre,
and you shall say to him,
'Thus says Lord Yahweh,
You were a proportioned seal,
[full of wisdom],
and complete in beauty.

¹³ You were in Eden, the garden of *Elohim*,
every precious stone was your covering,

*ruby, topaz, and jasper,
chrysolite, beryl, and jasper
sapphire, turquoise, and emerald
and settings and your mountings
were a work of gold
in the day you were created [they were prepared].*

¹⁴ *You are the cherub I set you [the outstretched one who covers];
[and] you were in the holy mountain of Elohim,
in the midst of the stones of fire [you walked about].*

¹⁵ *You were blameless in your ways
from the day you were created,
until iniquity was found in you.*

¹⁶ *Due to the abundance of your trade,
your midst was filled with violence
and you sinned,
so I defiled you from the mountain of Elohim,
and I banished you, [covering] cherub
from the midst of the fiery stones.*

¹⁷ *Your heart was raised high due to your beauty,
you corrupted your wisdom with your radiance,
I cast you down to the ground,
I give you over to kings, to look upon you.*

¹⁸ *Because of your great iniquities
in the wickedness of your trade,
you defiled your sanctuaries,
so I bring out fire from your midst,
it consumes you
and I will set you in the dust of the land,
in the eyes of all who see you.*

¹⁹ *All who know you among the peoples,
they will be appalled at you,
you will be an object of horror
and you will be no more.*

Challenging Interpretive Issues in Ezekiel 28:11-19

Who is being addressed?

The king of Tyre is the explicit addressee in 28:12 and also in the preceding oracle of 28:1-10, where he is called “chief of Tyre” (נְגִיד צֹר).

Ezekiel regularly uses allegorical and metaphorical portrayals of kings in order to more fully communicate their failures and the threat they pose to the cosmic order.

- In 28:1-10, chapter 17, and chapter 19, the final kings of Judah are lions and vines.

- In chapter 29, Pharaoh is a sea-dragon (*tannin*, תנין), and in chapter 32, he is compared to a lion and a sea-dragon.
- In chapter 31, Pharaoh is likened to Assyria, who is portrayed as a cosmic tree of the garden of Eden.

The Core Metaphors at Work

The version represented by the Septuagint depicts the king of Tyre as an Adam figure, the primal royal-priest in the garden of Eden who was made to perfectly represent the creator (“proportioned seal” is a metaphor for the image of Elohim in Gen. 1:26-28).

The jewels listed in 28:13 are clearly drawn from the high-priestly breastplate. The Septuagint text has 12 of the 12 gemstones worn by Israel’s high priest, the Masoretic text has only 9 of the 12 (see Exod. 28:17-20).

The link between the high priest (who was a royal figure with a crown) and the Eden ‘adam is built on the core biblical theme of humans as the representative image of *Elohim*. The priest is an image of ideal humanity, working in the ritual garden and representing humanity before God and representing God’s rule and presence in creation. Notice that elsewhere in Ezekiel, both Eden and the temple are associated with high mountains, an eternal river, and abundant life (see Ezek. 40:1-3, 47:1-12; Joel 3:17-18; Zech. 14:8; Ps. 46:4).

While the family of Israel was selected from among the nations to be Yahweh’s unique and special royal priesthood (see Exod. 19:4-6), the Hebrew Bible operates on the assumption that all humans, especially human rulers, are called to be images of *Elohim* as they rule and bear responsibility for the well-being of others. This is the foundation from which the Hebrew prophets accuse and hold the leaders of others nations accountable for their war crimes (see Amos 1-2; Isa. 10; Hab. 1-2; Obad. 1; Nah. 1-3).

This similarity between the human (‘adam) royal priests of Genesis 1-2, their failure in Genesis 3, and all other leading characters in the Hebrew Bible (especially kings, priests, and prophets) is fundamental to the communication strategy of the biblical story. It makes all the sense in the world that the king of Tyre would be likened to humanity in Eden.

Who or What is “The Cherub”?

In the Masoretic version of Ezekiel’s oracle, the Eden figure being compared to the king of Tyre is not the human, it is “the cherub,” a heavenly hybrid-figure elsewhere associated with guarding access to the divine presence in the garden (Gen. 3:24) and in the tabernacle and temple (Exod. 25:18-22 and 1 Kgs. 6:23-28). The cherub was appointed to patrol the garden (“walk about” / הַתְּהַלֵּךְ is precisely what the presence of Yahweh does in Gen. 3:8) and its treasures (“fiery stones” = brilliant and shiny gemstones, like those listed in Gen. 2:12).

The Hebrew text reflected in the Septuagint does not identify the figure with the cherub, but rather as someone else who is “with” the cherub in the garden, i.e., the primal image-bearing human. This link of the king of Tyre as ‘adam makes clear the original royal connotations of the *imago dei* (Gen. 1:26, “let them rule”).

Let’s look at the difference between the two versions.

- In the Masoretic version, the king is compared to a guardian angel-cherub who rebels against Yahweh and is banished. This fits precisely the depiction of the snake in Genesis 3.

- In the Septuagint version, the comparison is with Adam's rebellion and expulsion from the garden by a cherub.

What Is the Accusation?

In both versions, the fundamental sin of the royal figure is pride (taken from the preceding oracle in [Ezek. 28:1-10](#)), and a desire to be not just the image of *Elohim*, but to rule as an *elohim* in the divine seat of power (see 28:2).

The Hebrew text underneath the Septuagint version makes good sense, as it aligns with the humans' desire to take from the forbidden tree so that "they could become *elohim*" (see [Gen. 3:5](#)). While pride is not highlighted in the Eden narrative, it's not hard to see how it could be inferred from the narrative details, resulting in their expulsion out of the garden-temple by the guardian cherubim ([Gen. 3:24](#)).

The additions made to the oracle that resulted in the Masoretic version portray the arrogance of the king of Tyre as having an even more devious and primal origin. He is not simply another rebellious human replaying the folly of Adam and Eve. Rather, he is being driven by the dark spiritual forces that inspired that original rebellion, and who have been at work in and through human kings throughout the biblical narrative. It is that figure who was also expelled from the garden (in Ezekiel's retelling) and who is loose in the world continuing to deceive human leaders.

Rebel Adam or Rebel Cherub

It is likely that the shift in referent from the 'adam (Septuagint) to the rebel cherub (Masoretic text) took place when the book of Ezekiel was eventually integrated into the larger collection of the Torah and Prophets. Ezekiel 28 was then coordinated with many other similar passages in the Hebrew Bible that depict foreign kings as diabolical and inspired by the same spiritual powers at work in [Genesis 3](#).

- The seed of the snake, Cain's city, and Lemek: [Genesis 3:15](#) made it clear that the following narrative would feature characters who are the "seed" of the snake. This puzzling image is filled out by the narrative analogies at work in [Genesis 3](#) and [4](#). There, "sin" is an animal-like force (see [Gen. 4:7](#)) driving Cain's jealous anger. And in seven generations, it leads to Cain's city and the violent Lemek. *Lemek* is not a proper name in Hebrew, but the word "king" with the first two letters reversed (*melek/lemek*, מלך/למך)!
- Nimrod and Babylon: If Cain's building of his city that leads to Lemek is the first depiction of kings and cities in the Bible, then Nimrod and the establishment of Babylon is the second. Nimrod is explicitly described as one of the violent warriors, a *nephilim/gibborim* (see [Gen. 6:4](#) and [10:8-12](#)), and the founder of Babylon. The following narrative about Babylon is about humans seeking to make a name for themselves by ascending into the skies with a ritual tower (see [Gen. 11:1-10](#)).
- Babylon and the rebel divine council: Moses reflects back on the scattering of Babylon, and he sees another layer to that rebellion against Yahweh's authority. He depicts it as the rebellion of the heavenly host, which results in the nations being handed over to authority of dark spiritual powers (see [Deut. 32:7-10](#) and [Ps. 82](#)).
- Egypt and the rebel powers: In [Exodus 12:12](#), it becomes clear that the ten plagues were in fact an offensive not just against Pharaoh, but also against "the *elohim* of Egypt."
- Babylon, the snake, and the nations: In the prophets, this fundamental likeness between the snake and arrogant foreign kings is explored in multiple ways. In [Isaiah 14](#), the king of Babylon is metaphorically

portrayed as a rebel star (i.e., one of the “host of heaven”) who refuses to acknowledge the superior status of the sun. Isaiah draws upon ancient astrological themes as an analogy to describe the king of Babylon’s pride in storming the ancient world.

Isaiah 10:5-15 (Assyria) Instructor's Translation

⁵ Woe to Assyria, the rod of my anger
and the staff in whose hands is my indignation,

⁶ I send it against a godless nation
and commission it against the people of my fury
to capture booty and to seize plunder,
and to trample them down like mud in the streets.

⁷ Yet [Assyria] does not intend it in this way,
nor does it plan such a thing in its heart.
Rather, its purpose is to destroy and to cut off many nations.

⁸ For it says,
“Are not my princes all kings?

...

¹⁰ Just as my hand has reached to the kingdoms of the idols,
whose graven images were greater than those of Jerusalem and Samaria,

¹¹ won’t I do to Jerusalem and her images what I did to Samaria and her idols?”

...

¹³ For he has said,
**“By the power of my hand and by my wisdom I did this,
for I have understanding;**

Indeed, I removed the boundaries of the peoples,
and I plundered their treasures,

and like a valiant warrior I brought down their inhabitants,

¹⁴ and my hand reached to the riches of the peoples like a nest,
and as one gathers abandoned eggs, I gathered all the earth;
and there was not one that flapped its wing or opened its beak or chirped.”

¹⁵ Should the axe to boast itself over the one who chops with it?
Should the saw to exalt itself over the one who wields it?
That would be like a club wielding those who lift it,
Or like a rod lifting him who is not wood.

Isaiah 14:12-15 (Babylon) Instructor's Translation

¹² How you have fallen from the skies,
O star of the morning, son of the dawn!
You have been cut down to the land,
you who have weakened the nations!

¹³ **But you said in your heart,
‘I will ascend to the skies;**

**I will raise my throne above the stars of *Elohim*,
and I will sit on the mount of assembly,
in the recesses of the north;**

**14 I will ascend above the heights of the clouds;
I will make myself like the Most High.'**

¹⁵ On the contrary, you will be thrust down to Sheol,
to the recesses of the pit.

Obadiah 1:3-4 (Edom) NASB

³ "The arrogance of your heart has deceived you,
you who live in the clefts of the rock,
in the high exaltation of your dwelling place,
**you who say in your heart,
'Who will bring me down to earth?'**

⁴ **Though you build high like the eagle,
though you set your nest among the stars,
from there I will bring you down," declares the LORD.**

The Expulsion of the Snake or the Human?

The Masoretic text version of Ezekiel reflects a perspective on the Eden narrative that was implicit in [Isaiah 14](#) and Genesis 1-3. In Genesis 1, the rulers above (the host of heaven) are installed as God's delegated rulers of the skies, while humans are appointed as rulers below in the land. Human and spiritual powers are analogous to each other, each in their respective realms. Eden, however, is a merging of the two realms, as a place where Heaven and Earth are one (thus the equation of Eden with a "holy mountain" in [Ezek. 28:14](#)). We're told that the garden was populated with humanity, animals, but also spiritual beings, as there are *keruvim* posted at the exit gate to Eden. It is interesting that whenever these hybrid heavenly guardians are described, they are always different variations of animals, usually a mixing of land and sky creatures ([Exod. 25](#); [Isa. 6](#); [Ezek. 1](#)). It seems likely, then, that Ezekiel understood the snake to be a rebel *keruv*, and the Masoretic text version of Ezekiel supplies the backstory.

In other words, the Masoretic text of Ezekiel assumes that the traditions we encounter in Genesis 2-3 tell not only of the rebellion and exile of humanity from the garden, but also of the rebellion and exile of a spiritual being who deceived God's royal priests. The fall of Satan story stands right before us in Genesis 3, and Ezekiel compares the king of Tyre to the hubris and fall of that spiritual being.

#7 Oracle Against Sidon (Ezek. 28:20-23)

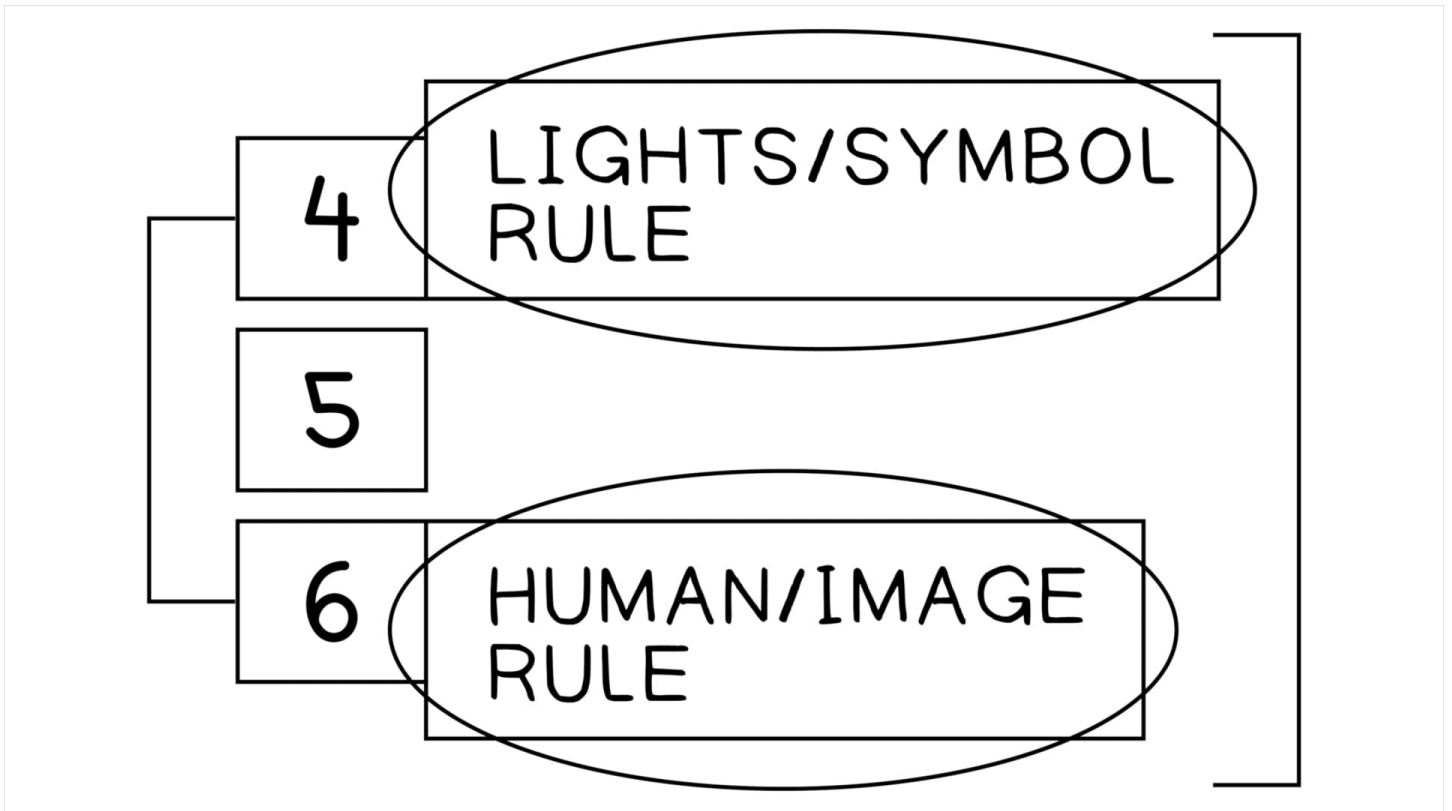
This series of oracles concludes with the condemnation of Sidon.

Judgment on the Nations, Restoration for Israel (Ezek. 28:24-26)

This little oracle is a brilliant compositional placement that coordinates all the promises of hope in chapters 1-24 with chapters 34-48 and links them with the judgment of the nations.

Yahweh's judgment on the nations is coordinated with Israel's future hope. A return to the land of Israel to live in peace links forward to chapters 46-48, and the vindication of Yahweh's name among the nations links forward to chapter 36.

Human and Spiritual Rulers in Genesis 1



Human and Spiritual Rulers in Genesis 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How do the biblical authors understand the conflict between Israel and the surrounding nations?